UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, BERKELEY
DEPARTMENT OF ECONOMICS

PLACEMENT SERVICE: Graduate Office
gradofc-econ@berkeley.edu

MARGARET KALLUS

margaret_kallus@berkeley.edu
https://margaretgkallus.github.io/

BUSINESS ADDRESS:
Department of Economics
530 Evans Hall, #3880
Berkeley, CA 94720-3880
Phone: +1 (845) 549-4131

RESEARCH AND TEACHING FIELDS:

PRIMARY
- Health Economics
- Public Economics
- Applied Microeconomics

SECONDARY
- Labor Economics

EDUCATION | **DEGREE** | **DATE**

UC Berkeley | Ph.D. in Economics | 2027 (expected)
Thesis: Essays on Insurers, Intermediaries, and Regulation in Medicare Markets
Committee: Jon Kolstad, Emmanuel Saez, Hilary Hoynes, Ben Handel
Fields of Concentration: Public Economics, Labor Economics

Washington and Lee University | B.S. in Mathematics and Economics | 2019
Summa Cum Laude, Honors in Economics, GPA 3.95

WORKING PAPERS:

- **"Deadpooling: Strategic Lock-In in the Medigap Market"** with Elaine Shen ***(Job Market Paper)***

  Abstract: The Medigap market prevents adverse selection by locking enrollees in to their initial plan; after an initial enrollment window, insurers may reject applicants who fail medical underwriting, and most enrollees do. We show that insurers exploit this lock-in through corporate structure. Linking two decades of NAIC filings to parent–subsidiary ownership records, we document *deadpooling*. In this financial practice, one subsidiary closes a plan to new enrollees, a sister subsidiary opens a replacement for healthy applicants, and premiums rise on the enrollees left behind who can no longer pass underwriting. From 2006–2020, 17.6% of Medigap life-years are spent in plans that deadpool. Using a Callaway–Sant'Anna staggered difference-in-differences design, we find that an enrollee who stays in their plan pays premiums $762 above open plans of the same type five years after closure. Each year, closures transfer $64.7 million from seniors to insurer profits and cost seniors $101.4 million in lost consumer surplus, including switching costs and lost coverage. Overall, consumers lose $1.57 in surplus per dollar of insurer gain. With variation from the staggered adoption of switching laws in six states, we find that allowing enrollees to switch plans annually reduces enrollment in deadpooling plans by 18%. A calibrated model shows that this can be explained by consumer inattention, and simulates market outcomes under alternate policies.

- **"The Price of `Free' Advice: Measuring Agency Problems in the Medicare Broker Market"** with Elaine Shen

  Abstract: Consumers turn to experts because they cannot evaluate complex choices, yet these same frictions can leave them unable to evaluate the experts themselves. Agency problems can therefore persist even in competitive, highly regulated markets. We study this problem in the Medicare insurance broker market, a market serving almost 70 million seniors and individuals with disabilities. We conduct an audit study where we hire senior "secret shoppers" to make 637 calls to randomly assigned brokers. Brokers provide at least one misaligned recommendation on 52% of calls and dominated recommendations can cost seniors over $12,000 in present-value lifetime wealth. A natural experiment eliminating broker commissions reduces steering towards a higher-commission plan by 21p.p., but does not eliminate it. A treatment variation designed to increase perceived competition by signaling that seniors will collect multiple recommendations causes brokers to recommend lower-priced plans. Competing on price, however, may also lower plan quality and consumer surplus. Using a structural model to estimate counterfactual policies, we find that supply-side reforms such as equalizing commissions and directing seniors to more experienced brokers lead to larger gains in consumer surplus than policies that can be directly implemented by seniors themselves (e.g. consumer feedback and competitive pressure). The findings highlight limitations to using consumer choice and competition to discipline markets for complex products.

- **"The Gap in Medigap: Disenrollment from Medicare Advantage Among Disabled Beneficiaries at Age 65"** with Daria Pelech

  Abstract: Medicare provides essential coverage for roughly 7 million disabled individuals, but fee-for-service Medicare's cost sharing can expose beneficiaries to substantial financial risk. Medigap plans help cover these costs, yet access for

beneficiaries under age 65 varies widely among states. Some states don't require insurers to offer Medigap coverage to younger beneficiaries; others permit substantially higher premiums. We combined Medigap premium data with beneficiary-level enrollment records to examine how Medigap policies affect coverage decisions. At age 65, all Medicare beneficiaries have guaranteed issue rights in Medigap; insurers must offer Medigap coverage without health-based underwriting. Using this policy change and variation in state regulations, we tested whether disabled beneficiaries disenrolled from Medicare Advantage (MA), Medigap's primary substitute. Among disabled beneficiaries enrolled in MA for at least one year, disenrollment at age 65 was roughly three times the baseline rate and varied substantially by state policy. Disenrollment increased most in states with limited Medigap access before age 65 and was lower where regulations expanded access and affordability. These findings suggest that Medigap policies significantly influence coverage choices among disabled Medicare beneficiaries.

WORK IN PROGRESS:

- "Insurance Agent Licensure: Turnover, Trends, and Spatial Differences"
- "Advertising and Persuasion in Medicare Insurance Markets" with Elaine Shen
- "Personality Testing in the Hiring Process" with Hadar Avivi and Elaine Shen

PUBLICATIONS:

- "The Economic Impacts of COVID-19: Evidence from a New Public Database Built Using Private Sector Data" (with Raj Chetty, John N. Friedman, Michael Stepner, and the Opportunity Insights Team), Quarterly Journal of Economics 139(2) (2024), 829–889.
- "Ruth-Aaron Pairs Containing Riesel or Sierpiński Numbers" (with Elliot Emadian and Carrie Finch-Smith), Integers 18 (2018).

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE:

RESEARCH:

Dissertation Fellow, Health Analysis Division, Congressional Budget Office, Washington, DC — June 2024–June 2026
Research with CBO economists on Medicare access.

Graduate Student Researcher, UC Berkeley, Berkeley, CA — May 2022–January 2023
With Professors Jon Kolstad and Ulrike Malmendier: cleaned and analyzed hospital audit data derived from Epic electronic health records.

Predoctoral Research Fellow, Opportunity Insights, Cambridge, MA — June 2019–June 2021
With Professors Raj Chetty, David Deming, John Friedman, and Nathaniel Hendren on the CLIMB Initiative (linked IRS, ACT/College Board, and university admissions data on low-income access to selective colleges) and the COVID-19 Economic Tracker (private-sector spending, job postings, firm closures, and unemployment insurance claims); analysis for academic papers and media (New York Times, Wall Street Journal).

Data and Policy Analyst Intern, Quality and Safety Division, Acumen, LLC, San Francisco, CA — June 2018–August 2018
Instrumental variables design and power analysis using Medicare claims to compare egg-based and cell-based flu vaccines; presented findings to FDA specialists.

Research Assistant, Washington and Lee University, Lexington, VA — June 2016–May 2019
With Professors Katie Shester and Chris Handy (Economics), Irina Mazilu (Physics), and Carrie Finch (Mathematics); honors thesis on the effect of fine particulate pollution on fertility, instrumenting with county NAAQS attainment status.

TEACHING:

Graduate Student Instructor, Department of Economics, UC Berkeley — Fall 2023–Spring 2025
Labor Economics, Intermediate Microeconomics, Introduction to Economics

Teaching Assistant, Department of Economics, Washington and Lee University — Fall 2018–Spring 2019
Econometrics

Teaching workshops: Creating and Using Grading Rubrics; Designing Syllabi for Summer Session Courses; Syllabus and Course Design; How Students Learn

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS:

2024–2026	Dissertation Fellowship, Congressional Budget Office
2025	Burch Center Fellowship (1 semester merit fellowship, full tuition and fees + stipend), UC Berkeley
2021-2023	Berkeley Fellowship (2 year merit fellowship, full tuition and fees + stipend), UC Berkeley
2015–2019	Johnson Scholarship (full-ride + stipend merit scholarship), Washington and Lee University
2019	Kim Family Prize (top economics thesis), Washington and Lee University
2019	John McKenzie Gunn Scholarship (economics department award), Washington and Lee University
2019	Omicron Delta Epsilon Economics Honor Society; Pi Mu Epsilon Mathematics Honor Society

2018 Phi Beta Kappa, Washington and Lee University

RESEARCH GRANTS:

Commonwealth Fund: Awarded funds to support research on the Medigap and insurance agent markets (2024, $50,000)

JPAL North America: Awarded funds to run a correspondence study analyzing insurance agent recommendations in the Medicare market (2025, $50,000)

Robert Wood Johnson Foundation: Awarded funds to explore heterogeneity in a study analyzing insurance agent recommendations in the Medicare market (2025, $25,000)

UC Berkeley XLab: Awarded funds from UC Berkeley Experimental Social Science Laboratory to run a survey of Medigap plan choice (2024, $4,000)

UC Berkeley Conference Travel Grant (2025, 2026)

UC Berkeley Dissertation Fellowship (2026)

Understanding America Survey (UAS): Awarded free questions to understand how seniors use insurance agents and shop for Medicare plans (2025); Awarded free questions to understand heterogeneity in senior plan shopping behaviors (2026)

PRESENTATIONS:

UC Berkeley Public Seminar (2025, 2026, Berkeley CA)

UC Berkeley Labor Seminar* (2026, Berkeley CA)

UC Berkeley IO Seminar* (2026, Berkeley CA)

ASHE (June 2025, Nashville TN*; June 2026, Minneapolis MN)

ASSA (January 2026, Philadelphia PA; January 2027, Washington D.C.*)

NBER Summer Institute Workshop on Aging* (July 2026, Cambridge MA)

SITE Psychology and Economics* (September 2026, Palo Alto CA)

** presented by a coauthor*

SERVICE AND VOLUNTEER:

Berkeley Economists for Equity, Berkeley, CA August 2021–Present

- Tutoring Initiative (Co-Coordinator 2023–2024); PhD Student Application Review; Job Market Candidate Profile Review; Student Research Grant Initiative Review

State Health Insurance Program Counselor (Volunteer), Alameda County HICAP September 2022–September 2023

- Completed >50-hour training about the US Medicare and CA Medicaid systems
- Counseled local seniors about their program eligibility and coverage under different insurance plans

Shelter Manager, Project Horizon Domestic Violence and Sexual Assault Shelter, Lexington, VA February 2017–May 2019

- Worked overnight managing 24-hour crisis hotline and domestic violence shelter

Undergraduate Women in Economics Advisory Committee; Tutor (Economics, Calculus), Washington and Lee University

OTHER INFORMATION:

Computer skills: Stata, Python, R, LaTeX, SAS, Microsoft Office Suite

Citizenship: United States

REFERENCES:

Professor Jon Kolstad, Haas School of Business and Department of Economics, UC Berkeley, jkolstad_place@lists.berkeley.edu

Professor Emmanuel Saez, Department of Economics, UC Berkeley, esaez_place@lists.berkeley.edu

Professor Hilary Hoynes, Goldman School of Public Policy and Department of Economics, UC Berkeley, hoynes@berkeley.edu

Professor Jim Campbell (teaching reference), Lecturer, Department of Economics, UC Berkeley, jcampbell_place@lists.berkeley.edu